

DeepSeek Access — Quick Guide

What you've been given

You have an **OpenRouter API key**. OpenRouter is a gateway that sits in front of DeepSeek. You call OpenRouter; OpenRouter calls DeepSeek using our organisation's DeepSeek account.

You do **not** need a DeepSeek account, and you do **not** pay for anything.

You → OpenRouter → DeepSeek

(your key) (our shared account)

Your key

Spend limit	\$120
Resets?	No — this is a one-time budget
Expires	7 days from issue
Model	deepseek-v4-pro

When you hit \$120, or when the 7 days are up, the key stops working. Nothing breaks silently — you'll get a clear error. Ask for a new key if you need one.

Treat the key like a password. Don't commit it to git, don't paste it in chat, don't share it. Each key is tracked separately, so usage is attributable to you.

Check your remaining limit

```
curl https://openrouter.ai/api/v1/key \
```

```
-H "Authorization: Bearer <PROVIDED_API_KEY>" | jq .
```

Look at:

- `limit` — your total (\$120)
- `limit_remaining` — what's left
- `usage` — what you've spent

If you don't have `jq`: `sudo apt install jq`

Quick test

Confirm the key works before you set anything else up:

```
curl https://openrouter.ai/api/v1/chat/completions \  
  
-H "Authorization: Bearer <PROVIDED_API_KEY>" \  
  
-H "Content-Type: application/json" \  
  
-d '{  
  
  "model": "deepseek/deepseek-v4-pro",  
  
  "messages": [{"role": "user", "content": "Say hello in one sentence."}],  
  
  "max_tokens": 64  
  
}'
```

You should get a normal JSON response with a message in it.

If you get **401** — the key is wrong or was copied incompletely. If you get **402** — the budget is exhausted or the key expired.

Claude Code setup

Set these environment variables:

```
export OPENROUTER_API_KEY="<PROVIDED_API_KEY>"
```

```
export ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL="https://openrouter.ai/api"
```

```
export ANTHROPIC_API_KEY="$OPENROUTER_API_KEY"
```

```
export ANTHROPIC_AUTH_TOKEN="" # Important: must be explicitly empty
```

```
export CLAUDE_CODE_ENABLE_GATEWAY_MODEL_DISCOVERY=1
```

```
export ANTHROPIC_MODEL=deepseek-v4-pro[1m]
```

```
export ANTHROPIC_DEFAULT_OPUS_MODEL=deepseek-v4-pro[1m]
```

```
export ANTHROPIC_DEFAULT_SONNET_MODEL=deepseek-v4-pro[1m]
```

Then start `claude` as normal.

Two details that trip people up:

- The base URL ends in `/api`, **not** `/api/v1`. Adding `/v1` will fail.
- `ANTHROPIC_AUTH_TOKEN` must be set to empty. If it's unset or has a value, Claude Code may try to authenticate against Anthropic instead of the gateway.

To make it permanent, put the block in `~/.bashrc` (or `~/.zshrc`) and run `source ~/.bashrc`.

Note on model names. Claude Code uses `deepseek-v4-pro[1m]`. Direct API calls use the full slug `deepseek/deepseek-v4-pro`. Both point at the same model.

Expect some rough edges. Claude Code is built and tuned for Anthropic's own models. Running it on DeepSeek works, but multi-step tool use is noticeably less reliable than you may be used to. It's a cost trade, not a like-for-like swap.

Watch your spend

Long agent sessions consume budget fast — Claude Code resends conversation context on every turn, so a long session costs much more than the same number of one-off questions. Check `limit_remaining` after your first real session so you get a feel for the burn rate.

Troubleshooting

Error	Meaning	Fix
401	Bad or truncated key	Re-copy the key
402	Budget exhausted or key expired	Request a new key
404 / model not found	Wrong model slug	Use <code>deepseek/deepseek-v4-pro</code>
Claude Code asks you to log in	Base URL or auth vars wrong	Check <code>ANTHROPIC_AUTH_TOKEN=" "</code> and the <code>/api</code> ending

Reference

- OpenRouter quickstart — <https://openrouter.ai/docs/quickstart>
- OpenRouter + Claude Code — <https://openrouter.ai/docs/cookbook/coding-agents/claude-code-integration>
- DeepSeek API docs — <https://api-docs.deepseek.com/>
- DeepSeek + Claude Code — https://api-docs.deepseek.com/quick_start/agent_integrations/claude_code/